



# M/J Spanish, Beginning

COURSE 0708000 • GRADES 7–8 • TWO SEMESTERS • OPTIMA ACADEMY ONLINE — FAMILY COURSE OVERVIEW

**About this overview.** This document is an example of how the course might be taught. It was drawn from one section of the course as taught this year, and each teacher leans into their own strengths and passions — so scholars may see some variation in activities, projects, and pacing from section to section, and between the live school and On-Demand. The structure, expectations, and time commitment below are representative of the course as designed.

**What this course is:** A first year of Spanish for middle schoolers, taught through daily practice and deep culture immersion. Semester 1 builds the foundation — pronunciation and the alphabet, greetings, the body and classroom, family, numbers, and the key verbs *ser*, *estar*, and *tener* — anchored in the culture of **Mexico** (Día de los Muertos, Mexican geography, art). Semester 2 turns to the engine of the language: conjugating present-tense verbs, from regular *-ar/-er/-ir* through the irregulars and stem-changers, applied to weather, home, food, and city life — with the cultural lens shifting to **Spain** and Puerto Rico.

## THE YEAR AT A GLANCE (by quarter)

- Q1 ¡Bienvenidos! Classroom commands, the body, alphabet & pronunciation, greetings; Mexican geography • **Culture Bag & Comic Strip projects, alphabet test**
- Q2 Family & Día de los Muertos; numbers to 100; *gustar*; *ser/estar/tener*; describing people • **Las Meninas art project, famous-person project, family tree**
- Q3 Present tense: regular *-ar/-er/-ir* verbs and *ir*; weather; the house & chores • **weather-forecast video project, oral assessment**
- Q4 Irregular & stem-changing verbs; Spanish music, food & shopping; the regions of Spain • **cooking project, VR Geography of Spain, final year-end test**

## PROJECTS & SPEAKING

- Creative projects every quarter: **Culture Bag, Maleta de México, comic strip, Las Meninas art, weather forecast, supermarket-cooking project, Geography of Spain in VR.**
- Many assessments pair written work with a **recorded speaking submission** — oral proficiency is emphasized all year.
- Fun traditions: New Year's grapes extra credit, "sing for my birthday to drop a test."

## A TYPICAL WEEK

- **Duolingo** — daily app practice; a 5-day streak earns full credit (screenshot submitted weekly)
- **Quizlet** vocabulary sets for the week's theme
- **Conjuguemos** verb-conjugation drills (Semester 2 especially)
- **Participation self-score** — students rate their own week, building honest self-government
- Every 2–3 weeks: a **VR cultural experience**, project, or assessment

## TIME COMMITMENT

**≈4 hours per week** (250 minutes — about 50 min/day, M–F)

Duolingo ≈1 hr (spread daily) • Quizlet/Conjuguemos practice ≈1½ hr • lessons, culture & VR ≈1 hr • projects/assessments ≈½ hr

*Per-part split is an estimate; the 250-minute weekly total comes from the school's course plan. Project weeks may run longer.*

## WHAT STUDENTS NEED

- A computer with access to Canvas
- Free accounts on **Duolingo, Quizlet, and Conjuguemos** (set up in week 1)
- A way to record short speaking videos; VR headset for VR experiences (live-school students use VR daily)

**On-Demand (asynchronous):** This overview describes the self-paced experience the course is designed for — students work through lessons on their own schedule with an Optima teacher available for support, feedback, and grading.

**Live school:** Students enrolled in the live virtual school take this same course in VR every school day with a teacher and classmates.